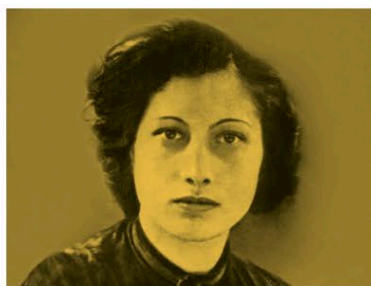


INTO THE line of fire

WORLD WAR II



BIOGRAPHY

NOOR INAYAT KHAN

Khan was born in Moscow in 1914 to an Indian father and an American mother. She was raised first in London and then in Paris, returning to England after the Nazi occupation of France. She became a radio operator with the British Special Operations Executive. In 1943, under the codename "Madeline," she became the first female radio operator to be sent to Nazi-occupied France. Later that year, she was betrayed; Khan was arrested by the Gestapo and executed along with three other women at Dachau in September 1944.

Whether as civilians caught up in the maelstrom of violence, members of the armed forces, or working as resistance operatives, women were fully exposed to the horrors of World War II. The war saw an unprecedented scale of attacks on civilian targets, in particular the widespread use of aerial bombardment, which placed millions of women at risk of death and serious injury. As the increasingly brutal conflict engulfed more and more of the world, millions of women were forced from their homes in search of safety. Tragically, thousands of women were raped by enemy soldiers, both opportunistically and as a strategic tactic (one that was later declared a war crime). The Red (Russian) Army estimatedly raped nearly one million German women between 1944 and 1945.

Women in uniform

The massive demands of World War II meant that hundreds of thousands of women entered military service. Germany and Japan were reluctant to consider recruiting women to the armed forces, so the vast majority of women in uniform fought for the Allied powers. Over 800,000 women served in the Soviet (USSR) armed forces, around 640,000 women served in British forces, and around 350,000 in the US armed services. They worked in a wide range of roles including as radio operators, gunners, drivers, and tank commanders. Female snipers were not uncommon; the USSR's Lyudmila Pavlichenko, who was credited with 309 kills, was the most lethal. Another Soviet heroine was Marina Raskova, who persuaded Stalin to

